

Understanding ICP

Cohort 10
Masterclass

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8th September 2026

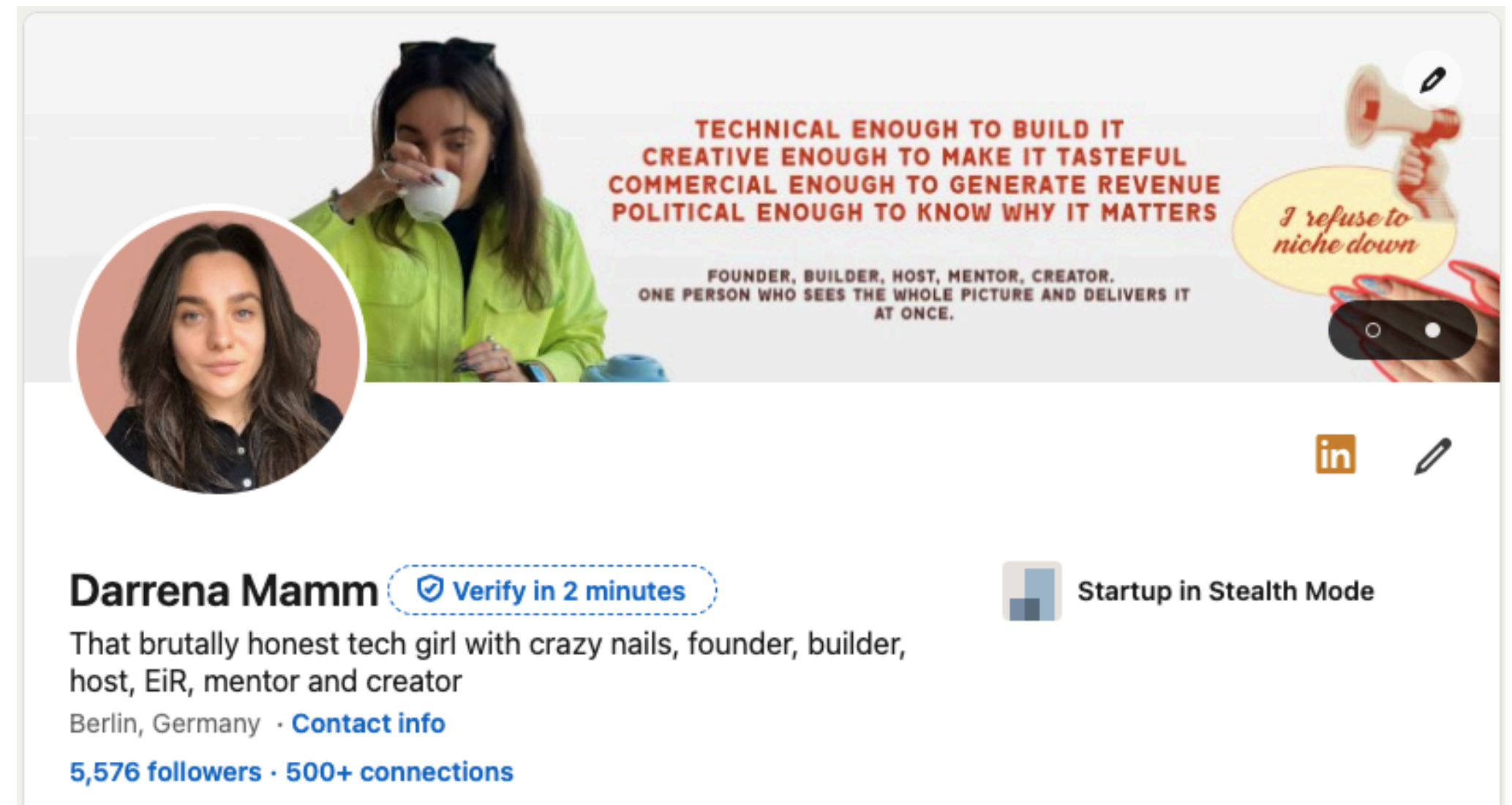


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Most Founders Get Their ICP Wrong At First

- The #1 startup killer is not competition - it's building for an imaginary customer. Founders fall in love with their solution before understanding the problem deeply enough.
- You are not allowed to guess - every assumption must be validated with a real human who would pay real money.
- 35% of startups fail due to no market need (CB Insights) - this is almost always an ICP problem. Not a product problem. Not a team problem.

What is even an ICP?

ICP IS NOT

- A demographic persona
("Marketing Manager, 35, likes coffee")
- A wishful description of your dream customer
- Static – defined once and forgotten

ICP IS

The specific segment that gets the **highest value** from your product, has the **budget to pay**, and is the **cheapest to acquire and retain**.

The test: Would they buy an ugly, unpolished version of your product? If yes – that is your ICP.

ICP = Who has the pain × Who can pay × Who you can reach

The 3 Filters Every ICP Must Pass

Do they have the pain? – Not a mild inconvenience. A costly, urgent, recurring problem they are already spending time or money to solve. If they live with it comfortably, it is not your ICP.

Are they willing to pay? – Budget exists, AND this problem ranks in their top 3 priorities. If it is #7 on their list, you will never close the deal – no matter how good your product is.

Will they switch? – Switching costs are real: habits, integrations, contracts, politics. Your ICP must have a strong enough "Why Now" to overcome inertia and make the move.

If a prospect fails any one filter, they are not your ICP, no matter how much you want them to be.

The "Why Now" Signal

- The best ICP is not just someone with the pain – it's someone whose situation just **changed** and made the pain unbearable.
- **Common triggers** – New funding round, regulatory change, leadership change, competitor move, team scaling, failed internal solution, M&A activity.
- **Triggered buyers close faster** – Triggered buyers close 3–5× faster and churn far less. They bought because they *had* to, not because they were convinced over time.
- **Build trigger-based lists** – Use LinkedIn, Crunchbase, job postings, and news alerts to find prospects at their exact moment of pain.

Buyer vs. User vs. Champion

Role	Who They Are	What They Care About	Risk If You Lose Them
Buyer (Economic Decision Maker)	Controls budget. Rarely uses the product daily.	ROI, risk, compliance, cost savings	Deal never starts
User (End User)	Lives inside the product daily. Rarely controls budget.	Speed, ease, workflow, time saved	Adoption fails, churn follows
Champion (Internal Advocate)	Power user who feels the pain most acutely. Sells your product upward internally.	Solving their pain, looking good internally	Deal dies internally — no one to push it forward

In B2B: you must win all three. Lose the champion → deal dies internally. Lose the buyer → it never starts.

In B2C: buyer and user are often the same — but not always (parents/children, IT/employees).

B2B, B2C, B2E, B2G

Market	Sales Cycle	Who Decides	ICP Must Include
B2B	6–18 months	5–12 stakeholders, ROI-driven	Company size, industry, tech stack, org structure, budget owner
B2C	Impulse to 30 days	Individual, emotion + social proof	Psychographics, triggers, channels – not just demographics
B2E	Top-down purchase, bottom-up adoption	HR/IT buys, employees use	Two ICPs: the buyer (CHRO/CTO) and the user (employee)
B2G	12–36 months	RFP-driven, relationship-heavy	Agency type, budget cycle, compliance requirements



ICP by Stage

Stage	Your ICP Status	What To Do	Key Signal
Idea Stage	ICP is a hypothesis	Run 20+ interviews. Do not build anything yet. Your only job is to find the pain.	People describe the problem without prompting
Prototype Stage	ICP is being tested	Show, don't tell. Put something in front of people and watch what they do — behavior beats opinion.	They use it without being asked to
MVP Stage	ICP is emerging	Study whoever tolerates the bugs and keeps coming back. They are your early adopters.	Retention despite imperfection
Mature Stage	ICP is data-driven	Mine your data. Highest retention + highest NPS + most referrals = your real ICP. Let data override assumptions.	Referrals and organic growth

Wishlist ICP vs. Reality ICP vs. Worst Customer

Type	Who They Are	The Problem	What To Do
Wishlist ICP	The Fortune 500 logo you dream of	Long sales cycle, low win rate, crushes your roadmap with custom requests that serve no one else	Pursue selectively – only after you have strong PMF
Reality ICP	Who actually buys, pays on time, gets value fast, and refers others	None — these are your growth engine	Double down. Find more like them. Build for them.
Worst Customer	High churn, low NPS, constant support tickets, never refers anyone	Costs more than they pay. Pulls product in the wrong direction.	Fire them. Refund them if needed.

Go niche to go big – dominate one segment completely before expanding.

The Road to the ICP

Who do our direct competitors serve right now?

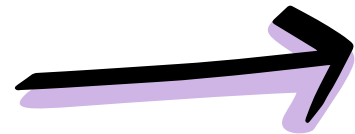


What is the core, high-priority, painful problem their customer have/ You solve (too)?
(Not a feature, a problem).



The "Cost of Inaction": If the customer doesn't use your product, what will they lose (money, time, market share, health, connection)? This loss must be palpable.

Of the filtered companies/ people, which ones are also easiest to acquire and serve?
(Crucial for first-time founders!)



Easy to Reach:
Do they cluster on a specific platform?
conference, location?
network?



Low Barrier to Entry: Can you sell to them directly, or is there a huge procurement process?

High Value Potential: Will they be willing to pay a premium for solving this pain?



Why else would they use your product? Secondary value.



Why would they become disloyal to the current solution?
Can you build into the current solution?

How to Find Your ICP: The Discovery Interview

Volume & Who to Talk To

- **20–30 interviews minimum;** patterns only emerge after 15+
- Under 10 interviews is anecdote, not signal
- Talk to people who have the problem today
- Talk to people who tried to solve it and failed
- Talk to people who bought a competitor's solution

The Golden Rule

Ask about past behavior, never future intent.

"Would you use this?" – no value

"What did you do last time this happened?" – value

Listen For

- Emotional language – frustration, urgency
- Workarounds they built themselves
- Money already being spent on the problem

Discovery Interview Script

Step	Question to Ask	What You Are Looking For
1. Open the pain	"Walk me through the last time [problem] happened. What did you do?"	Emotional language, urgency, workarounds
2. Quantify the cost	"How much time or money does this cost you per week or month?"	Budget signal, priority level
3. Reveal the trigger	"What would have to happen for you to make solving this a top priority tomorrow?"	The "Why Now" — urgency driver
4. Uncover the buyer	"If you decided to buy a solution, who else would need to be involved?"	Decision-making structure, stakeholders
5. Test switching	"What are you using today? What would it take for you to leave it?"	Switching cost, competitive landscape
6. Close with commitment	"Would you be a beta user / pay for early access / intro me to 2 others with this problem?"	Real intent vs. polite interest

Record every interview. The exact words customers use become your marketing copy.

Why ICP Is the Foundation of Everything

- **Product Roadmap** – Features are driven by customer pain.
- **Marketing** – The right audience and the landing message are defined by customer feedback/reaction.
- **Sales** – No qualification criteria = no efficiency of sales (we don't guess, we validate)
- **Unit Economics** – LTV:CAC – optimizing CAC or LTV makes for a more viable business.

Every mistake multiplies:

Wrong ICP → wrong features → wrong messaging → wrong hires → wrong investors.

ICP → Product → Positioning → PMF: The Chain That Cannot Break

The failure loop: wrong ICP → generic product → weak positioning → no PMF → pivot → repeat.

Stage	What It Does	What Breaks Without It
ICP	Defines who has the pain and will pay	Everything downstream is built on wrong assumptions
Product	Built to solve that specific ICP pain – features chosen by need, not founder preference	Generic product that satisfies no one deeply
Positioning	Translates product into language the ICP recognizes as "this is for me"	Messaging that resonates with no one
PMF	ICP says "I'd be very disappointed if this went away" (Sean Ellis: >40% = PMF signal)	Endless pivots with no traction

ICP Drives Every Team's Decisions

Team	How ICP Guides Them	What Happens Without ICP
Product	Defines which features get built. Every request outside the ICP's core pain is a distraction.	Roadmap driven by loudest voice, not best customer
Marketing	Tells you the exact words that resonate and where your customer spends time.	Wasted ad spend on the wrong audience with the wrong message
Sales	Gives criteria to disqualify fast. Bad-fit prospects are the #1 sales efficiency killer.	Time wasted on deals that will never close
Finance	Defines LTV:CAC ratio. Healthy business needs $LTV \geq 3 \times CAC$.	Unit economics impossible to optimize — business not viable

ICP Hypothesis Template

Field	Your Answer
Who	[Job title / role / type of person or company]
Pain	[The specific, costly problem they have right now]
Current Solution	[What they use today – spreadsheet, competitor, nothing]
Trigger	[What event makes them actively look for a solution]
Budget Signal	[Evidence they spend money on this problem already]
Success Metric	[How they measure if the problem is solved]
Disqualifiers	[Who looks like the ICP but is NOT – be explicit]

Use Competitors to Reverse-Engineer Your ICP

- **Read their 1-star reviews** – on G2, Capterra, Trustpilot, App Store. Free, unfiltered ICP research. What do their customers hate?
- **Analyze their positioning** – who are they ignoring? The underserved segment is your beachhead.
- **Study their job postings** – who they hire reveals who they sell to and what problems they are prioritizing next.
- **Follow their customers on LinkedIn** – what are they complaining about? What content do they engage with?
- **Run this quarterly** – competitor analysis is not a one-time exercise. Markets shift, and so does your ICP.

Common ICP Mistakes That Kill Startups

- **Targeting everyone (FOMO)** – "Our product works for any company" = built for no one. The broader your ICP, the weaker your product, messaging, and win rate.
- **Defined once, never revisited** – ICP must be updated every 6 months minimum. Markets shift, your product matures, and your best customers change.
- **Confusing enthusiasm with intent** – "This is so cool!" ≠ "I will pay for this." Always ask for money or a concrete commitment. Applause is not validation.
- **Ignoring the "Why Now"** – A customer without a trigger will stay interested forever and never buy. No urgency = no deal.
- **Building for the loudest customer, not the best customer** – The noisiest users are rarely your ICP. They optimize for their edge case, not the core need that drives your real growth.

Your ICP Operating System

- **Document it** – ICP is a living document: firmographics, psychographics, pain triggers, buying process, and explicit disqualifiers. Write it down.
- **Validate it** – 20+ interviews per quarter. Every data point confirms or challenges your ICP. Stop when you hear no new information.
- **Enforce it** – Every sales call, feature request, and marketing campaign must pass through the ICP filter.
- **Evolve it** – Your ICP at idea stage $\neq$ your ICP at Series A. Revisit after every major milestone. The market gives you new data – use it.

The best founders don't guess their ICP. They build a system to find it, test it, and sharpen it — continuously.

Q & A

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